



Mount Pinatubo

A brooding volcano in the Philippines with a history of extraordinarily violent eruptions



△ SUMMIT LAKE

Since 1992, Pinatubo's 1½-mile (2.5-km) wide caldera has been filled with a turquoise lake. With a depth of 2,000 ft (600 m), it is the deepest lake in the Philippines.

The volcano Pinatubo on the island of Luzon in the Philippines does not erupt frequently, but when it does, it explodes with extreme ferocity. It has produced some exceptionally large eruptions at intervals of anything from 500 to 8,000 years.

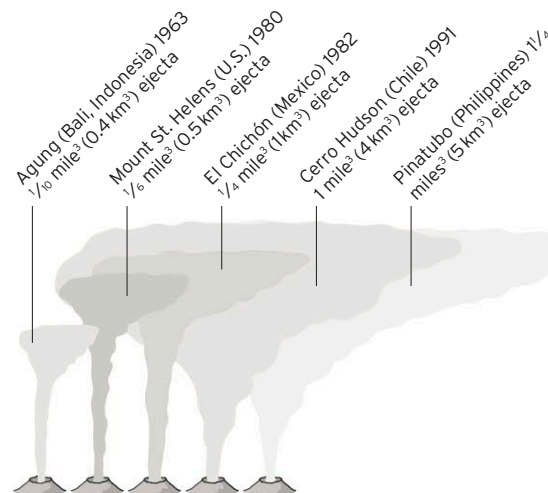
Pinatubo in 1991 and today

The most recent of Pinatubo's eruptions occurred in June 1991, when a series of explosions sent a vast quantity of rock and ash into the atmosphere and produced pyroclastic flows (avalanches of hot gas and ash) that incinerated land up to 11 miles (17 km) away. More than 800 people died, and thousands more were displaced. Part of the top of the volcano collapsed, leaving a summit caldera that is now filled with a tranquil lake. Ash darkened the sky for many days, and fine particles of dust and tiny droplets of sulfuric acid spread all around Earth. These droplets blocked out sunlight, lowering global temperatures by 1°F (0.5°C) for a year.

Even today, some of the effects of the eruption can be seen in the form of vast, deep fields of ash all around the volcano. Pinatubo is closely monitored for any further activity.

THE 1991 ERUPTION OF PINATUBO

Pinatubo's 1991 eruption is the largest, most violent volcanic event of the past 100 years in terms of the volume of ash, lava, pumice, and other materials ejected. Here, it is compared to four other massive eruptions since 1950.



△ MUSHROOM CLOUD

During Pinatubo's 1991 eruption, a cloud of volcanic ash was launched 21 miles (34 km) into the air, forming a mushroom shape. This is far higher than most commercial airliners fly.